INFRAUD.ORG

UPI Request Scams

A practical beginner’s guide to understanding payment requests, spotting social engineering, and protecting your money.

LEVEL	CURRICULUM	TOPIC
Beginner	4 lessons	UPI safety

What you will learn

- Understand the difference between sending money and receiving money through UPI.
- Recognise fake collect requests, QR-code tricks, refund scams, and urgency tactics.
- Check a payment request safely before approving anything.
- Know what to do immediately if money is debited or credentials are exposed.

THE MOST IMPORTANT RULE

You do not enter your UPI PIN to receive an ordinary incoming payment. Entering your UPI PIN in a payment app authorises a debit/payment or another clearly described UPI action. Always read the app screen before approving.

How to use this guide

Read the four lessons in order. Each lesson includes a plain-language explanation, practical examples, and actions you can practise. Finish with the safety checklist and quiz. This guide is educational; it does not replace advice from your bank, payment app, or law-enforcement authorities.

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Your learning path

Section	What it covers
Lesson 1	UPI basics: paying versus receiving
Lesson 2	How request scams work and common tricks
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Quick reference	Before-you-pay checklist and warning signs
Knowledge check	Quiz, answers, and key terms
Sources	Official guidance and reporting links

A SIMPLE MENTAL MODEL

When you pay someone, you authorise money to leave your account. When someone pays you, money should arrive as a credit. A request asking you to approve or enter a PIN is not proof that money is being sent to you.

LESSON 1 | UPI BASICS

Paying money vs. receiving money

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) lets people transfer money between bank accounts using a supported app. It is convenient, but payment features can be misused to pressure people into approving payments they did not intend to make.

1.1 When you pay someone

You choose the recipient, enter or confirm the amount, review the details shown by your UPI app, and authorise the payment using the required authentication, such as your UPI PIN. After authorisation, money is debited from your account and sent to the recipient.

PAUSE BEFORE ENTERING YOUR PIN

Check the recipient name, UPI ID or account details, amount, and purpose shown on the payment screen. If anything is unexpected, cancel. Do not rely only on a name or screenshot sent by another person.

1.2 When someone sends you money

For an ordinary incoming UPI payment, you should not need to enter your UPI PIN to receive the money. Check your own UPI app or bank account transaction history for a credit. Do not treat a message, screenshot, phone call, or a stranger's claim as proof that payment has arrived.

1.3 What is a collect/request request?

A collect request is a request asking you, the payer, to approve a payment to the requester. If you approve it and authenticate it, money may be debited from your account. A scammer may describe this as "accept to receive money", "claim your reward", or "approve your refund". The wording in a message does not change what the payment screen is asking you to do.

1.4 The PIN rule

• Never tell your UPI PIN to anyone, including someone claiming to be from a bank, police, a payment app, or customer support.

• Never enter your UPI PIN because a caller says it is needed to receive a refund, prize, salary, or payment.

• Only enter your PIN inside your trusted UPI app when you personally intend to authorise the transaction displayed on screen.

• An OTP, UPI PIN, app passcode, and transaction reference are different things. Do not share authentication codes.

REMEMBER

Receiving money = verify the credit in your own account. Paying money = you authorise a debit. A collect request is a request for you to pay, not proof that someone has paid you.

How UPI request scams work

Most request scams combine a believable story with pressure. The scammer wants you to act before you read the payment screen carefully. They may contact you through a phone call, messaging app, marketplace listing, social media, email, or fake customer-care number.

2.1 Common scam scenarios

Fake buyer / marketplace scam

How it works: A person says they want to buy an item you listed. They send a collect request or QR code and tell you to approve it to receive the buyer's payment or booking amount.

Safer response: A buyer does not need your UPI PIN to send you money. Confirm any incoming credit in your own app.

Fake refund or cashback

How it works: Someone claims a payment failed and asks you to approve a request to receive a refund, cashback, or prize.

Safer response: A refund should not require you to pay an unknown person. Verify refunds through the merchant or app's official support channel.

QR-code "receive money" trick

How it works: A caller sends a QR code and says scanning it will put money into your account.

Safer response: A QR code can take you to a payment flow. Read the app screen; do not enter your PIN to receive money.

Fake customer support

How it works: A scammer impersonates a bank or payment app representative and asks you to share a PIN/OTP, install a remote-access app, or approve a request.

Safer response: End the call. Contact your bank or app using the official app, card, or website—not a number supplied by the caller.

Urgent family / emergency request

How it works: A person impersonates a relative, colleague, or authority and demands an immediate transfer, claiming there is no time to verify.

Safer response: Call the person using a number you already know. Confirm independently before sending money.

KYC, account block, or disconnection threat

How it works: A message says your account, SIM, or service will be blocked unless you click a link, call a number, or make a payment immediately.

Safer response: Do not use the link or phone number in the message. Check directly with the official provider.

2.2 Pressure tactics to recognise

• **Urgency:** "Do it in two minutes or the offer expires."

• **Authority:** "I am from your bank / police / payment company."

- **Secrecy:** “Do not tell anyone; this is confidential verification.”
- **Confusion:** They keep you on the phone while you navigate the app quickly.
- **Small test payment:** They ask you to approve a small amount first, then request a larger payment.

A GOOD RULE

A genuine person can wait while you verify. If someone gets angry, threatens you, or refuses independent verification, stop the interaction.

How to check a UPI request safely

Use this routine every time you receive a payment request, especially when it comes from someone you do not know or when the story involves a refund, reward, delivery, job, or emergency.

3.1 The five-step check

1. Stop

Do not act while a caller or message is rushing you. Close the chat or end the call if needed.

2. Read the app screen

Open your UPI app yourself. Read whether the screen says you are paying, approving a collect request, setting a mandate, or doing something else.

3. Check the recipient

Confirm the displayed payee name and UPI ID with the person or business through a separate trusted channel.

4. Check the amount and purpose

Make sure the amount is exactly what you intended. Watch for recurring payments, mandates, or unexpected debit authorisations.

5. Decide—or cancel

If you did not initiate the payment, do not recognise the recipient, or do not understand the request, decline/cancel it. Contact your bank or app through official support.

3.2 Example: a marketplace buyer

Situation: You list a used phone for sale. A buyer says they will pay an advance and sends a QR code. They tell you to scan it and enter your UPI PIN to receive the advance.

What to notice: The buyer is asking you to take an action inside your payment app. If the screen asks you to pay or approve a request, money may leave your account.

Safe action: Do not enter the PIN. Ask the buyer to send payment normally. Check your own account for a credit before handing over the item.

3.3 Example: a collect request from a known contact

Even if the name looks familiar, verify through a separate call or conversation you initiate. Accounts can be compromised, names can be misleading, and payment requests can be sent by mistake. Do not approve a request simply because it appears to come from a saved contact.

3.4 Safe habits

• Keep your UPI app and phone operating system updated.

• Use the app’s official in-app complaint/help option for transaction disputes.

• Enable bank SMS and app notifications so you can notice unexpected debits.

• Never install screen-sharing or remote-access apps at the request of an unknown caller.

• Do not search randomly for customer-care numbers; use official websites or the app.

• Protect your phone lock, SIM, email, and bank account credentials.

• Do not share screenshots that reveal account details, balances, transaction IDs, or personal information publicly.

BE CAREFUL WITH MANDATES

A mandate or autopay instruction can authorise future debits under its terms. Read the amount, frequency, start/end dates, and cancellation options before approving. Do not approve a mandate just to receive money.

LESSON 4 | IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

What to do after a suspected UPI fraud

If you approved a suspicious request or notice an unauthorised debit, act immediately. Quick reporting may help the relevant institutions take action, but recovery is not guaranteed.

4.1 Immediate response

1. Contact your bank immediately

Use the official bank app, website, or number printed on your card. Report the unauthorised transaction and ask the bank to register a complaint and advise on securing the account/UPI access.

2. Call 1930 promptly

For cyber financial fraud in India, call the National Cyber Crime Helpline 1930 as soon as possible.

3. Submit the online complaint

Use the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal at https://cybercrime.gov.in. Follow the instructions given after calling 1930 and retain the acknowledgement/reference number.

4. Raise a UPI app complaint

Use the transaction details and in-app dispute/help option in the UPI app. You may also contact the relevant bank/payment provider.

5. Preserve evidence

Keep transaction ID/UTR, date and time, amount, recipient UPI ID, bank SMS, screenshots, phone numbers, chat messages, and complaint references. Do not edit or delete the original evidence.

6. Secure accounts and devices

Change compromised credentials through official channels, secure affected payment access as advised by your bank, remove suspicious remote-access apps, and check for further unauthorised activity.

REPORT FINANCIAL CYBER FRAUD

Call 1930 and report online at **https://cybercrime.gov.in**. Report quickly, keep the acknowledgement number, and follow the portal/bank instructions. Reporting does not guarantee that money will be recovered.

4.2 Information to keep ready

- Your contact number and the name of your bank/payment app.
- Transaction ID / UTR, amount, date, and approximate time.
- Recipient UPI ID or account details shown in the transaction.
- Screenshots or copies of messages, calls, links, and payment requests.
- Bank complaint number and cybercrime acknowledgement number.

4.3 What not to do after a fraud

- Do not pay a stranger who promises guaranteed recovery of your money.
- Do not share OTP, UPI PIN, card details, passwords, or remote access.
- Do not delete messages or transaction evidence before saving copies.
- Do not delay reporting while trying to negotiate with the suspected scammer.

• Do not assume a complaint automatically reverses a transaction; follow up with your bank and official reporting channel.

QUICK REFERENCE

Before-you-pay checklist

Pause and check every item before approving a UPI payment or request.

Question	If the answer is NO or UNCLEAR
Did I start this payment myself?	Stop. Do not approve an unexpected request.
Do I recognise and trust the recipient?	Verify using a separate, known contact method.
Does the displayed amount match what I intend to pay?	Cancel if the amount is wrong or unclear.
Does the screen clearly describe the action?	Do not enter the PIN until you understand it.
Am I being rushed, threatened, or told to keep it secret?	End the interaction and verify independently.
Am I being asked for my PIN or OTP by another person?	Never share it. A genuine support agent does not need it.

Red flags at a glance

• “Enter your UPI PIN to receive money.”

• “Scan this QR code to get your refund or prize.”

• “Approve this collect request so I can send you money.”

• “Share your OTP/PIN with me to verify your account.”

• “Install this app and share your screen so I can help.”

• “Pay immediately or your bank account / SIM / electricity will be blocked.”

• “Do not call the official bank number; use the number I am giving you.”

A PAYMENT REQUEST IS NOT A PAYMENT RECEIPT

A notification saying “request received” means someone is asking you to act. It does not mean money has been credited to you. Verify credits in your own bank/UPI transaction history.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Quick quiz

Choose the safest answer for each situation. Answers are provided below.

1. A stranger says you must enter your UPI PIN to receive ■2,000.

A. Enter the PIN quickly

B. Decline and verify; do not enter the PIN to receive money

C. Share the PIN on a call

2. You receive a collect request from an unknown UPI ID. What does it ask you to do?

A. Approve a payment to the requester

B. Confirm that money has arrived

C. Update your phone number

3. A buyer sends a QR code and says it will credit money to your account.

A. Scan and enter PIN

B. Ask them to send payment normally and verify the credit

C. Share an OTP

4. You notice an unauthorised UPI debit. What should you do?

A. Wait a week

B. Contact your bank and report promptly through 1930 / the portal

C. Pay a recovery agent

5. A caller claims to be bank support and asks for your UPI PIN.

A. Share it if they know your name

B. Share only half

C. Refuse and contact the bank through official channels

6. A payment screen shows a different amount than you intended.

A. Cancel and verify

B. Approve because the person is waiting

C. Ignore the amount

Answer key and explanations

1. B — A UPI PIN is not required to receive an ordinary incoming payment.

2. A — A collect/request flow asks the payer to approve a request.

3. B — Do not treat a QR code as a receive-money tool; verify a credit in your own account.

4. B — Contact your bank immediately and report promptly through 1930 and the official portal.

5. C — Never disclose your PIN; contact the bank independently.

6. A — Never approve a transaction with an unexpected amount.

GLOSSARY & OFFICIAL SOURCES

Important terms

UPI	Unified Payments Interface; an instant payment system for bank-account transfers through supported apps.
UPI ID / VPA	A virtual payment address used to identify a UPI user or account for payments.
UPI PIN	A secret authentication PIN used to authorise relevant UPI transactions. Never share it.
Collect request	A payment request sent to a payer asking them to approve a transfer.
QR code	A scannable code that may open a payment flow. Inspect the details shown in your app.
UTR / Transaction ID	A reference used to identify a payment transaction. Keep it for complaints and follow-up.
Mandate / Autopay	An instruction that can allow future debits under specified terms. Review amount, frequency, and validity.

Official references

This guide is based on official or primary sources. Check the latest instructions directly at these links:

NPCI – UPI FAQs
https://www.npci.org.in/what-we-do/upi/faqs
UPI basics, UPI PIN, collect requests, transaction complaints.

RBI – Safe Digital Banking Practices
https://www.rbi.org.in/Scripts/BS_PressReleaseDisplay.aspx?prid=53185
RBI warnings about phishing, remote-access apps, misuse of UPI collect requests, and never sharing PINs/OTPs.

RBI – Safeguards for Digital Banking
https://rbikehtahai.rbi.org.in/safeguards-for-digital-banking.html
General digital banking safety practices.

National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal
https://cybercrime.gov.in/
Official Government of India portal; financial cyber fraud helpline 1930.

National Cyber Crime Portal – Report Suspect
https://cybercrime.gov.in/Webform/cyber_suspect.aspx
Facility for reporting suspicious websites, phone numbers, messaging identifiers, and other suspect details.

IMPORTANT LIMITATION

This guide is for awareness and education. INFRAUD analysis is not a bank confirmation, account-ownership verification, or guarantee that a UPI ID or transaction is safe. Verify payment details inside your own trusted UPI app and contact your bank through official channels.

Prepared for the INFRAUD.ORG Safety Guides curriculum | Beginner | 4 lessons

Check Before You Trust.